

Theory of Constraints

Find the one place the whole flow narrows, squeeze it before you spend on it, make everything else serve it, then follow it to wherever it moves next.

BEST FOR A PROJECT, A PROBLEM · ELIAHU GOLDRATT, 1984 · TAKES AN HOUR TO FIND IT, WEEKS TO SERVE IT

HOW TO RUN IT

1. Describe the system: what it exists to get through, the stages the work passes through in order, and the number that goes up when more gets through.
2. Name the places the flow might narrow. For each, look for the evidence: what piles up in front of it, and who or what sits idle after it. Commit to one. A wrong constraint worked properly teaches you more than a right one never committed to.
3. Exploit it. List the moves that recover capacity the constraint already has, without spending anything: stop it doing work that isn't its job, stop feeding it broken input, stop letting it sit idle at handovers.
4. Subordinate everything else. Decide what changes away from the constraint so that it never waits and never drowns, and say whose numbers get worse on purpose. If nobody's do, nothing has been subordinated. Tell them yourself.
5. Only if squeezing wasn't enough, elevate: spend on more capacity at the constraint specifically. An empty elevate step is a result, not a gap.
6. Ask where the constraint stands now. If it has moved, name the step it moved to, note which rules from this round must not become policy, and start again from the top on the new one.

Where it falls down. People find a constraint and then try to fix three things at once, or name three constraints and spread the effort across all of them, which is the same failure.

WITH A PEN

The system

What it gets through. The flow, start to end. How you'd measure it

Candidates

Signs of queueing / the constraint, a contributor, cleared

Exploit: squeeze it, free

What each move recovers

Subordinate

What changes elsewhere. Whose numbers get worse

Elevate, only if squeezing wasn't enough

Capacity at the constraint specifically

Has it moved?

Where it lives now. What from this round must not become policy